

# ANCIENT EGYPT

Clothing in ancient Egypt was drab by modern standards: it was typically off-white, the natural colour of linen. It is not surprising, then, that the Egyptians adorned themselves with vividly-coloured gems such as amber, turquoise, lapis lazuli, and carnelian, although a glass-like, glazed ceramic known as Egyptian faience was also used. Gems were showcased in wide semi-circular collars worn by both men and women, with counterweights hanging down their backs to keep the jewellery in place. Wigs were popular, and richly ornamented headpieces and circlets kept them from slipping. Earrings, bracelets, and amulets were also worn by all classes, further enhancing a wearer's appearance.

Gems had great spiritual significance as well, and were often worn for protection, to ward off evil, or to attract the attention of good spirits. Red stones such as carnelian and red jasper were considered powerful because of their resemblance to the colour of blood, which stood for life and longevity. Greenish-blue turquoise from the Sinai represented fertility, healing, and rebirth, while deep blue lapis lazuli from Afghanistan was especially significant, symbolizing the heavens, death, and the afterlife.

Gold, carnelian, and feldspar Egyptian necklace, c.1991–1786 BCE



**Egyptian guests at a banquet** This wall painting from the tomb of Nebamun, an Egyptian official who lived in the 18th dynasty, around 1350 BCE, depicts banquet guests with the women wearing elaborate gowns and wigs, and decorated with precious jewels.

